

## SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

# RATIONALISM (Descartes, Spinoza, Leibniz) - Syllabus Item 2 (Paper I - Section A)

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

### RATIONALISM: ONE METHOD, THREE METAPHYSICAL SYSTEMS

Reason + innate/intellectual principles + deduction

| DESCARTES                              | SPINOZA                                     | LEIBNIZ                                     |
|----------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| <b>SUBSTANCE COUNT</b> 3               | <b>SUBSTANCE COUNT</b> 1                    | <b>SUBSTANCE COUNT</b> ∞                    |
| <b>CRITERION</b><br>Real distinction   | <b>CRITERION</b><br>Strict independence     | <b>CRITERION</b><br>Simplicity + activity   |
| <b>ONTOLOGY</b><br>God + mind + matter | <b>ONTOLOGY</b><br>God or Nature            | <b>ONTOLOGY</b><br>Windowless monads        |
| <b>MIND-BODY</b><br>Interaction        | <b>MIND-BODY</b><br>Parallelism             | <b>MIND-BODY</b><br>Pre-established harmony |
| <b>FREEDOM</b><br>Libertarian will     | <b>FREEDOM</b><br>Freedom through necessity | <b>FREEDOM</b><br>Compatibilist agency      |

Attribute separates → independence unifies → simplicity multiplies

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge → official current linkage → clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

# RATIONALISM (Descartes, Spinoza, Leibniz) - Syllabus Item 2 (Paper I - Section A)

## 10. PYQ ROUTING (2018–2025)

ANALYSIS: **Corpus signal:** 14 primary-owned question-parts out of 112. The local Paper I corpus is continuous from 2018 through 2025. Cross-links do not create duplicate ownership.

| Year | Question | Marks    | Exact demand                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|------|----------|----------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 2018 | Q1(b)    | 10 marks | Is there any place for freedom in Leibniz's philosophy, when he speaks of 'pre-established harmony'? Discuss.                                                                                                                  |
| 2018 | Q2(a)    | 20 marks | What is the reason for the difference in the definitions and classifications of substances made by Descartes, Spinoza and Leibniz in spite of the fact that they all belonged to the rationalist school of thought? Discuss.   |
| 2019 | Q1(d)    | 10 marks | How does Descartes prove the existence of things other than himself and God? Discuss.                                                                                                                                          |
| 2019 | Q2(c)    | 15 marks | What do you understand by Spinoza's statement that what is, cannot be other than what it is? Explain.                                                                                                                          |
| 2020 | Q1(b)    | 10 marks | How does Leibniz's conception of monads bear upon his views on determinism and freedom? Discuss with your own comments.                                                                                                        |
| 2020 | Q4(b)    | 15 marks | "From the necessity of the divine nature there must follow infinitely many things in infinitely many ways." Explain this statement by Spinoza along with some possible criticisms.                                             |
| 2022 | Q2(c)    | 15 marks | Discuss the concept of substance according to Spinoza. Does his discussion on substance lead to pantheism? Substantiate your view.                                                                                             |
| 2022 | Q4(b)    | 15 marks | How does Rene Descartes explain the notion of certainty with reference to knowledge of the self? Critically discuss the way it differs from the knowledge of the world.                                                        |
| 2023 | Q1(c)    | 10 marks | "That thing is said to be free which exists solely from the necessity of its own nature, and is determined to action by itself alone." Discuss Spinoza's views on freedom and determinism in the light of the above statement. |
| 2023 | Q2(c)    | 15 marks | Discuss Descartes' theory of innate ideas and the grounds on which Locke refutes it.                                                                                                                                           |
| 2024 | Q2(b)    | 15 marks | How does Spinoza establish that God alone is absolutely real with his statement — "Whatever is, is in God"? Critically discuss.                                                                                                |
| 2024 | Q3(c)    | 15 marks | Among the rationalists, whose account of mind-body problem is compatible with the notion of human freedom and free will? Critically discuss.                                                                                   |
| 2025 | Q2(a)    | 20 marks | What are the basic tenets of Rationalism? How does Descartes build a system of Philosophy in consonance with them? Discuss.                                                                                                    |
| 2025 | Q2(b)    | 15 marks | "All determination is negation." Comment with reference to Spinoza.                                                                                                                                                            |

See the Western Philosophy PYQ Bank, 2018–2025.

## 11. ANSWER ARCHITECTURE (10 / 15 / 20 marks) ANALYSIS:

### 10-mark: "Spinoza's views on freedom and determinism" (2023)

Line 1: Spinoza holds strict determinism – everything follows necessarily from God's nature; nothing is contingent.

Body : (i) "Free will" is an illusion born of ignorance of causes (stone analogy).  
(ii) Freedom ≠ contingency; freedom = self-determination through adequate ideas.  
(iii) "That thing is free which exists solely from the necessity of its own nature and is determined to action by itself alone" (Eth. I, Def. 7).  
(iv) Only God is absolutely free; humans approach freedom via adequate knowledge.

Eval : Freedom is reconceived, not abandoned – but libertarian critics say this is determinism renamed.

Close : "Discuss" = present + assess; close with whether this is genuine freedom or verbal.

### 15-mark: "All determination is negation — comment with reference to Spinoza" (2025)

Frame : In Spinoza's monist system, the one substance (God) is infinite and unlimited.

Body A: "Determination" = making something definite, finite, bounded. To say X is \*this\* is to say X is \*not\* everything else → hence negation.

Body B: Consequence for finite things: they are \*limitations\* (negations) within the infinite substance. They lack independent being; they are what God is not.  
Consequence for God: God, being infinite, involves \*no\* negation – He is pure affirmation, unlimited, undetermined by anything external.

Body C: Implication for knowledge: to know finite things adequately is to see them sub specie aeternitatis – as expressions of the one affirmative substance, not as independent negations. Link to freedom (adequate knowledge = seeing necessity).

Assess: Powerful ontological insight, but critics charge it dissolves individuality (Hegel's acosmism objection); finite things become mere "negations" without intrinsic worth.

Close : "Comment" = brief pointed assessment; end on whether the formula illuminates or obliterates the finite.

### 20-mark: "Basic tenets of Rationalism; how Descartes builds a system in consonance" (2025)

Frame : Rationalism = reason is the source of certain knowledge (vs empiricism).

Body A: The tenets – innate ideas, deductive method, intelligibility of reality, substance metaphysics, reason over sense (table from §1.5).

Body B: Descartes' system step by step:  
(i) Method of doubt → cogito (reason alone; no reliance on sense).  
(ii) Innate idea of God → proofs of God (trademark, ontological).  
(iii) God guarantees CDI → rebuilds mathematics + external world.  
(iv) Substance metaphysics (3 substances – res cogitans, res extensa, God).

Body C: How each step instantiates a tenet. Contrast with empiricist counter (Locke's attack on innate ideas; Hume's fork).

Assess: Descartes' system is internally coherent but fragile – it depends on the cogito not being circular and on God's proof not begging the question.

Close : Descartes does not merely \*assert\* rationalist tenets; he \*constructs\* a system that \*\*embodies\*\* them as its operating logic.

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## D. DIRECTIVE DECODER ANALYSIS: — what each command word obliges you to do here

| Directive (as printed in UPSC Philosophy)                                 | What it demands                                                       | Structural obligation for this file                                                                                                                                                                    | Fatal error                                                              |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Discuss</b>                                                            | exposition + assessment, both substantial                             | Two-part body: doctrine reconstructed as numbered steps, then a weighing paragraph. ~60:40 split.                                                                                                      | Pure exposition with no evaluative sentence.                             |
| <b>Critically discuss / examine</b>                                       | assessment must <b>dominate</b>                                       | Reconstruct in 3–4 lines, then spend the bulk on objection -> reply -> adjudication. Verdict is compulsory.                                                                                            | Listing criticisms without ruling between them.                          |
| <b>Comment</b> (e.g. 2025 Q2b "All determination is negation")            | short, pointed, <i>thesis-first</i>                                   | Open by stating what the sentence <b>means in Spinoza's own system</b> , not what it means generally; then one consequence for God, one for finite modes, one for knowledge; then a one-line judgment. | Treating "comment" as an invitation to write a general essay on Spinoza. |
| <b>Explain</b> (2019 Q2c, 2020 Q4b)                                       | make the doctrine <b>intelligible</b> , showing <i>why</i> it follows | Foreground the derivation: from Def. 7 / P16 / P29, not from summary.                                                                                                                                  | Restating the quotation in other words.                                  |
| <b>Substantiate your view</b> (2022 Q2c)                                  | you must <b>take a side</b> and defend it with textual grounds        | Declare "yes, it entails pantheism, in the following precise sense...", then defend against the acosmism reading.                                                                                      | Sitting on the fence.                                                    |
| <b>Discuss with your own comments</b> (2020 Q1b)                          | an explicit <b>first-person evaluative</b> paragraph is being marked  | Reserve the last 25% for a signposted personal adjudication.                                                                                                                                           | Omitting the personal verdict.                                           |
| <b>Whose account is compatible with...? Critically discuss</b> (2024 Q3c) | a <b>comparative ranking</b> with a defended winner                   | Rank all three explicitly against a stated criterion of freedom; then defend the ranking.                                                                                                              | Describing all three neutrally.                                          |
| <b>What is the reason for the difference...?</b> (2018 Q2a)               | <b>explanatory</b> , not descriptive                                  | The answer is a <i>mechanism</i> : one inherited definition + three different applications of the independence criterion.                                                                              | Tabulating the three views without explaining the divergence.            |

## V. GRADED VERDICT BANK ANALYSIS: — executable closing positions (10 / 15 / 20)

Each verdict is a **defensible position**, not a summary. Use verbatim or compress.

| Sub-topic               | 10-mark verdict (1 sentence)                                                                                                                                                            | 15-mark verdict (2–3 sentences, with the concession)                                                                                                                         | 20-mark verdict (thesis + mechanism + cost)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|-------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Cartesian method</b> | The method of doubt is not scepticism but scepticism's instrument: it is used to destroy itself, and it succeeds only because the cogito is performatively, not inferentially, certain. | ...Its success is local. The cogito secures the <i>existence</i> of a thinker but not the <i>substantiality</i> of the thinker; Hume and Kant both exploit exactly this gap. | Descartes' method delivers a genuine indubitable, but the reconstruction built on it is only as strong as the divine guarantee — so the <i>Meditations</i> stand or fall on Meditation III, not Meditation II. The Cartesian Circle is therefore not a peripheral blemish but the system's load-bearing joint. |

| Sub-topic                       | 10-mark verdict (1 sentence)                                                                                                                          | 15-mark verdict (2–3 sentences, with the concession)                                                                                                                                                      | 20-mark verdict (thesis + mechanism + cost)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
|---------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Wax argument</b>             | The wax argument proves not that bodies exist but that, if known, they are known by intellect — self-knowledge is epistemically prior.                | ...It succeeds against naive empiricism because no sensory item registers <i>identity through change</i> ; it fails to establish apriority, since the empiricist can call "extension" an abstraction.     | Meditation II already installs extension as body's essence, so Meditation VI's dualism is partly presupposed rather than proved; the wax argument is thus the hinge on which Cartesian dualism silently turns.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| <b>Substance (all three)</b>    | The three rationalists differ not because they disagree about the <i>definition</i> of substance but because they differ on how strictly to apply it. | ...Descartes applies it loosely (admitting dependent "created substances"), Spinoza strictly (only the wholly independent qualifies — hence one), Leibniz adds <i>simplicity</i> (hence infinitely many). | The trio is a single argument unfolding: Spinoza's monism is the <i>consistent</i> Descartes, and Leibniz's pluralism is the <i>consistent</i> rejection of extension as an essence. The lesson is that "substance" is not a discovery but a criterion, and the metaphysics you get is the criterion you enforce.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| <b>God</b>                      | For Descartes God is a <i>guarantee</i> , for Spinoza God <i>is the system</i> , for Leibniz God is a <i>selector</i> .                               | ...Only Spinoza's God does no explanatory work outside the system, which is why only his is immune to Kant's critique of the ontological argument; Descartes' and Leibniz's both require it.              | Kant's demolition of the ontological proof ("existence is not a real predicate") kills Descartes' and Leibniz's God but leaves Spinoza's untouched, because Spinoza does not <i>infer</i> God's existence from a concept — he identifies God with the totality of what is. Spinoza therefore survives the Enlightenment critique that destroys his fellow rationalists.                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| <b>Mind–body</b>                | The three solutions are not three answers to one question but three verdicts on whether the question is well-formed.                                  | ...Descartes accepts the question and cannot answer it; Spinoza dissolves it by denying the two-substance premise; Leibniz dissolves it by denying causation altogether.                                  | Judged by explanatory economy Spinoza wins, judged by fidelity to experience Descartes wins, judged by systematic consistency Leibniz wins — and the fact that no single criterion selects one answer is itself the strongest evidence that Descartes bequeathed a <i>pseudo-problem</i> rather than a problem.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| <b>Freedom / determinism</b>    | Spinoza does not abolish freedom, he relocates it — from the will's indifference to the intellect's adequacy.                                         | ...Whether that is freedom or determinism renamed depends on whether one thinks "could have done otherwise" is essential to freedom; Spinoza denies it, and consistently.                                 | Ranking against a stated criterion: if freedom requires alternative possibilities, only Descartes qualifies, at the price of an unintelligible interaction; if freedom requires <i>self-determination</i> , Spinoza qualifies best; if it requires reconciling determination with responsibility, Leibniz's spontaneity + intelligence + contingency is the most workable. The examiner-safe ruling: <b>Leibniz</b> , because his is the only account that keeps both the determination the metaphysics requires and the responsibility ethics requires. |
| <b>Three kinds of knowledge</b> | Spinoza's three kinds are three <i>ontological positions of the knower</i> , not three degrees of confidence.                                         | ...This makes epistemology and ethics one subject — his most original move; but because <i>scientia intuitiva</i> is self-certifying ( <i>verum index sui</i> ), it is also his most vulnerable.          | The tripartite scheme is what converts Spinoza's necessitarianism from a fatalism into an ethics: because knowing adequately <i>is</i> acting from one's own nature, the discovery that all is necessary is itself the act by which one becomes free. Its price is that Spinoza cannot give an external criterion distinguishing the third kind from confident imagination.                                                                                                                                                                              |

## T. TRANSLATION, QUOTATION & PROVENANCE DISCIPLINE FACT:

**Rule of the file:** quote *verbatim* only where a standard English edition is being followed and named; elsewhere **paraphrase and mark it as paraphrase**. Never present a reconstructed sentence in quotation marks.

| Text                                                                                        | Standard editions                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    | Safe practice                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Descartes, <i>Meditations on First Philosophy</i> (Latin 1641; French 1647)                 | Cottingham–Stoothoff–Murdoch, <i>The Philosophical Writings of Descartes</i> (CSM, CUP 1984) — the scholarly default; older Haldane–Ross (1911) still common in Indian editions                                                                                                                                                                      | <b>Wording differs between CSM and Haldane–Ross.</b> <i>Solius mentis inspectio</i> is "purely mental scrutiny" (CSM) but "inspection of the mind" (Haldane–Ross). Either write " <i>inspectio mentis</i> — rendered 'purely mental scrutiny' in CSM" or paraphrase. |
| <i>Cogito, ergo sum</i>                                                                     | Latin phrase appears in the <i>Discourse</i> (1637, French: <i>je pense, donc je suis</i> ) and <i>Principles</i> I.7; the <i>Meditations</i> has the first-person "I am, I exist" formulation                                                                                                                                                       | FACT: Safe to quote the Latin tag. WRONG: Do <b>not</b> attribute " <i>Cogito ergo sum</i> " to the <i>Meditations</i> — the <i>Meditations</i> runs "I am, I exist, is necessarily true whenever it is put forward by me or conceived in my mind."                  |
| Spinoza, <i>Ethics</i> ( <i>Ethica</i> , posthumous 1677)                                   | Curley, <i>Collected Works of Spinoza</i> Vol. I (Princeton 1985) — current standard; Elwes (1883) and White–Stirling are the older public-domain versions widely reprinted in India                                                                                                                                                                 | Cite by <b>structural reference</b> ( <i>Eth.</i> I, Def. 7; I, P15; II, P7; II, P40S2; V, P32C) rather than page. Structural references are translation-invariant and impress; page numbers do not.                                                                 |
| <i>Omnis determinatio est negatio</i>                                                       | ANALYSIS: <b>Provenance caution.</b> The exact Latin formula is <b>not</b> in the <i>Ethics</i> . Spinoza writes <i>determinatio negatio est</i> in <b>Letter 50 to Jarig Jelles (2 June 1674)</b> . The universalised slogan " <i>omnis determinatio est negatio</i> " is <b>Hegel's</b> rendering, which is how it entered the textbook tradition. | Write: "Spinoza's dictum, in Letter 50, that determination is negation — universalised by Hegel as <i>omnis determinatio est negatio</i> ." This exactly answers PYQ 2025 Q2(b) <b>and</b> earns a provenance mark.                                                  |
| <i>Deus sive Natura</i>                                                                     | <i>Eth.</i> IV, Preface, and IV, P4 Dem.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             | FACT: Safe verbatim.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| Leibniz, <i>Monadology</i> (1714, French; published posthumously 1720 German / 1840 French) | Latta (1898); Ariew–Garber, <i>Philosophical Essays</i> (Hackett 1989)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               | "Monads have no windows" is a <b>standard rendering</b> of <i>Monadology</i> §7 ("Les Monades n'ont point de fenêtres"), not a literal English original. FACT: Safe as a rendering; say "as it is usually rendered."                                                 |
| "Best of all possible worlds"                                                               | <i>Theodicy</i> (1710); <i>Monadology</i> §§53–55                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    | FACT: Safe. Note it is Leibniz's own French <i>le meilleur des mondes possibles</i> ; Voltaire's <i>Candide</i> (1759) satirises it as " <i>tout est au mieux</i> ."                                                                                                 |
| "Incline without necessitating"                                                             | <i>Theodicy</i> ; also Leibniz–Clarke correspondence                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 | FACT: Standard rendering of <i>incliner sans nécessiter</i> .                                                                                                                                                                                                        |

WRONG: **Never write:** "Descartes says the mind is a ghost in the machine." That is **Ryle's** hostile coinage (*The Concept of Mind*, 1949), not Descartes'. Attribute it correctly and the same sentence becomes a mark-earner.

## 12. LINK-OUTS

- ../\_themes/Substance-across-western.md — the full Aristotle -> Descartes -> Spinoza -> Leibniz -> Locke -> Hume -> Kant thread.
- ../\_themes/A-priori-a-posteriori-knowledge.md — the rationalist claim to a priori knowledge; contrasted with Hume and resolved by Kant.
- Empiricism.md — the rival tradition; Locke's attack on innate ideas directly counters Descartes.

- Kant .md — Kant synthesises rationalism + empiricism; rescues causality from Hume while limiting metaphysics.
- .../paper-2/philosophy-of-religion/Proofs-for-God.md — Descartes' ontological & causal arguments treated in the cross-paper Religion context; Kant's refutations.
- .../paper-2/philosophy-of-religion/Notions-of-God.md — Spinoza's impersonal pantheistic God.
- PYQ bank: .../PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2018-2025.md.

## SOURCES

- Masih, Y., *A Critical History of Western Philosophy* — chapters on Descartes, Spinoza, Leibniz.
- Copleston, F., *A History of Philosophy*, Vol. IV (Descartes to Leibniz).
- Nigel Warburton, *Philosophy: The Classics*, chapters on Descartes' *Meditations* and Spinoza's *Ethics* (local PDF, pp. 103–146 in the file pagination).
- Robert Audi (ed.), *The Cambridge Dictionary of Philosophy*, entries on Descartes, Spinoza and Leibniz (local PDF, especially file pages 257–259, 904–906 and 524–527).

# PART II — COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION AND SOLVED PRACTICE

## Learning Roadmap

| Stage      | Subtopic            | What must be mastered                                     | Exam payoff                                           |
|------------|---------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| Foundation | Rationalist project | a priori reason, innate ideas, deduction, intelligibility | Define the school without reducing it to “anti-sense” |
| Core 1     | Cartesian certainty | doubt, cogito, wax, God, external world                   | Reconstruct Descartes as an ordered system            |
| Core 2     | Substance           | Descartes 3 -> Spinoza 1 -> Leibniz ∞                     | Highest-yield comparative route                       |
| Core 3     | God                 | guarantor -> immanent reality -> rational selector        | Compare explanatory roles, not merely proofs          |
| Core 4     | Mind-body           | interaction -> parallelism -> harmony                     | Rank solutions by freedom and explanatory economy     |
| Core 5     | Freedom             | libertarianism -> rational necessity -> compatibilism     | Handle quotation-led and comparative questions        |
| Advanced   | Live disputes       | Cartesian Circle, attributes problem, infinite analysis   | Add qualified evaluation in 15/20 markers             |
| Exam       | PYQs and drills     | 14 verified PYQs, MCQs, remedial and Mains practice       | Convert doctrine into directive-faithful answers      |

**Source note:** Static Philosophy does not require an artificial current-affairs anchor. The teaching design uses argument maps, contrastive matrices, worked answers and retrieval practice because these formats make premises, objections and philosophical differences visible.

## Visual 1 — The Rationalist Transformation

## RATIONALISM: ONE METHOD, THREE METAPHYSICAL SYSTEMS

Reason + innate/intellectual principles + deduction

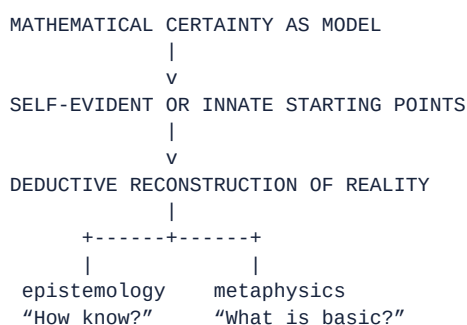
| DESCARTES                              | SPINOZA                                     | LEIBNIZ                                     |
|----------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| SUBSTANCE COUNT <b>3</b>               | SUBSTANCE COUNT <b>1</b>                    | SUBSTANCE COUNT <b>∞</b>                    |
| <b>CRITERION</b><br>Real distinction   | <b>CRITERION</b><br>Strict independence     | <b>CRITERION</b><br>Simplicity + activity   |
| <b>ONTOLOGY</b><br>God + mind + matter | <b>ONTOLOGY</b><br>God or Nature            | <b>ONTOLOGY</b><br>Windowless monads        |
| <b>MIND-BODY</b><br>Interaction        | <b>MIND-BODY</b><br>Parallelism             | <b>MIND-BODY</b><br>Pre-established harmony |
| <b>FREEDOM</b><br>Libertarian will     | <b>FREEDOM</b><br>Freedom through necessity | <b>FREEDOM</b><br>Compatibilist agency      |

Attribute separates → independence unifies → simplicity multiplies

*Rationalism: from one method to three metaphysical systems*

The visual tracks the decisive movement: a shared confidence in reason produces three incompatible ontologies because each thinker applies the test of substance differently.

### Subtopic 1 — What Makes Rationalism a School?



Rationalism is not the thesis that sensation is useless. It is the stronger claim that sense-experience cannot by itself yield necessity, universality or an indubitable foundation. Reason supplies principles whose authority does not depend on repeated observation. Descartes therefore searches for an indubitable first truth; Spinoza deduces a necessary order *more geometrico*; Leibniz explains reality through principles such as sufficient reason and the identity of indiscernibles.

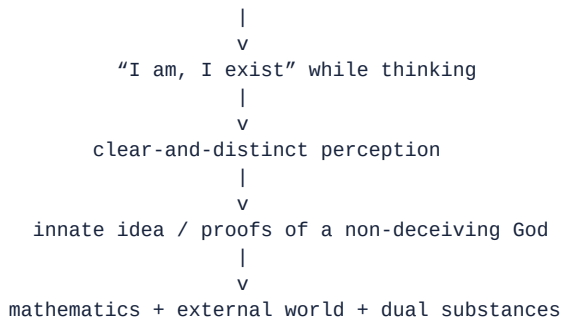
**Worked discrimination.** “All rationalists accept innate ideas” is broadly useful but incomplete. What unites them more deeply is a confidence that reality has an intelligible structure and that reason can move from privileged principles to that structure. Their disagreement over substance shows that a method does not mechanically dictate one metaphysics.

**UPSC trap:** Do not define rationalism as the denial of experience. Define it by the source and status of *certain* knowledge.



## Subtopic 2 — Descartes: From Demolition to Reconstruction

Sense error -> Dream -> Evil demon



The order matters. The cogito defeats total doubt only at the point of the thinking act. It does not immediately establish a permanent soul, other minds, God or the material world. The wax argument then shows that bodily identity through change is judged by intellect, while the divine guarantee is used to extend certainty beyond the presently attended cogito.

### Named evidence and what it proves

| Evidence                         | Philosophical work           | What it proves                                                  | Qualification                                                           |
|----------------------------------|------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Dream and evil-demon arguments   | <i>Meditations</i> I         | ordinary and mathematical beliefs can be suspended methodically | doubt is an instrument, not Descartes' final position                   |
| "I am, I exist"                  | <i>Meditations</i> II        | the occurrence of thought is performatively indubitable         | existence of a thinker does not yet prove a substantial soul            |
| Wax and hats-and-coats cases     | <i>Meditations</i> II        | judgement/intellect structures apparent perception              | an empiricist can call extension an abstraction from experience         |
| Trademark and ontological proofs | <i>Meditations</i> III and V | a perfect non-deceiver is made the bridge to stable knowledge   | Arnauld's Circle objection attacks this bridge                          |
| God is no deceiver               | <i>Meditations</i> VI        | involuntary sensory ideas support an external material cause    | this proves material reality more securely than every perceived quality |

### Mini-evaluation

Descartes obtains a genuine local certainty: doubting cannot occur without thinking existence. The larger system is less secure because the proof of God appears to use the very clear-and-distinct perceptions whose general reliability God is supposed to guarantee. The cogito is therefore the strongest point; the reconstruction is the contested point.

## Subtopic 3 — Substance: One Definition, Three Applications

| Test               | Descartes                               | Spinoza                                    | Leibniz                              |
|--------------------|-----------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| Basic unit         | God, mind, matter                       | God or Nature alone                        | infinitely many monads               |
| Decisive criterion | real distinction by principal attribute | strict self-existence and self-conception  | simplicity plus internal activity    |
| Count              | 3 kinds                                 | 1                                          | $\infty$                             |
| Cost               | "created substance" is dependent on God | individuals lose independent substancehood | bodies become well-founded phenomena |

**The explanatory mechanism:** Descartes uses "substance" analogically: God is absolutely independent, while mind and matter depend only on God. Spinoza refuses this looseness; if substance must be conceived through itself, only the infinite can qualify. Leibniz agrees that extended composites cannot be ultimate but rejects Spinoza's single substance: true units must be simple, active and internally differentiated, hence monads.

**Memory chain:** Attribute separates -> independence unifies -> simplicity multiplies.

## Claim–objection–reply tree

DESCARTES: thought and extension are really distinct  
 objection: dependent created things fail his definition  
 reply: “substance” is analogical, not univocal

SPINOZA: strict independence permits one substance only  
 objection: modes become unreal; acosmism  
 reply: modes are real as expressions, not as independent beings

LEIBNIZ: ultimate substance must be simple and active  
 objection: windowless monads make correspondence miraculous  
 reply: pre-established harmony preserves plurality without influx

## Subtopic 4 — God: Guarantee, Reality, Selector

| Thinker   | God’s function                                     | Named doctrine                                    | Analytical consequence                     |
|-----------|----------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| Descartes | secures truth and creates finite substances        | trademark, ontological and conservation arguments | epistemology depends on theology           |
| Spinoza   | is the sole substance and immanent cause           | <i>Deus sive Natura</i> ; <i>Ethics</i> I P15/P18 | creation becomes necessary self-expression |
| Leibniz   | explains the contingent series and chooses a world | PSR; best possible world                          | divine wisdom coordinates monads           |

The strongest comparison asks what explanatory work “God” performs. Descartes’ God validates cognition; Spinoza’s God is not an added cause but the immanent structure of reality; Leibniz’s God selects and harmonises. This also changes freedom: Cartesian divine creation permits a finite free will, Spinoza’s divine nature acts necessarily, and Leibniz’s God chooses among possibles according to sufficient reason.

## Subtopic 5 — Mind and Body: Three Responses to One Inheritance

Are mind and body two substances?

YES | DESCARTES

v

interaction -> causal gap

NO: one substance, two attributes | SPINOZA

v

parallel order -> no cross-attribute causation

MANY: every true substance is a monad | LEIBNIZ

v

no interaction -> divinely pre-established correspondence

### Ranking requires a criterion.

- If freedom means genuine alternative possibilities, Descartes ranks first, but his interaction mechanism is obscure.
- If freedom means action from adequate understanding of one’s nature, Spinoza ranks first, but libertarian freedom disappears.
- If freedom means determined yet responsible agency, Leibniz ranks first: spontaneity, intelligence and contingency preserve a compatibilist space.

The examiner-safe answer to the 2024 comparative PYQ is therefore Leibniz, provided the criterion is stated. A bare assertion that “Leibniz preserves freedom” without explaining hypothetical necessity, internal spontaneity and possible worlds earns little.

## Subtopic 6 — Determinism and Freedom

| Axis                | Descartes                               | Spinoza                                 | Leibniz                                                |
|---------------------|-----------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| Determination       | mechanical body does not determine will | every mode follows necessarily          | complete concept settles the series                    |
| Freedom             | ability to assent, deny or withhold     | acting from one's own understood nature | spontaneity + intelligence + contingency               |
| Error/bondage       | will outruns finite intellect           | inadequate ideas and passive affects    | confused perception and external-looking compulsion    |
| Best textual anchor | <i>Meditations</i> IV                   | <i>Ethics</i> I Def. 7; II P7; V        | <i>Discourse</i> , <i>Monadology</i> , <i>Theodicy</i> |

Spinoza's decisive move is to reject freedom as uncaused choice. The conscious stone imagines itself free because it knows its motion but not its cause. Yet the free person is not passive: adequate understanding makes the mind an adequate cause of action. Leibniz instead distinguishes certainty from absolute necessity. Caesar's crossing may be contained in Caesar's complete concept and certain to God, while its opposite remains logically possible in another world.

## Subtopic 7 — Advanced Refinements

### 7.1 Cartesian Circle

**Objection:** Descartes trusts clear-and-distinct perception to prove God and God to validate clear-and-distinct perception. **Reply:** present intuition is self-evident while attended to; God guarantees remembered or extended reasoning. **Judgement:** this softens but does not eliminate the problem, because the divine proofs themselves employ remembered premises.

### 7.2 Spinoza's attributes problem

**Issue:** substance has infinitely many attributes, but human beings know only Thought and Extension. **Strong reading:** attributes are genuine expressions of the whole divine essence, not parts. Human cognition is structurally limited. **Objection:** unknown attributes appear explanatorily idle. **Reply:** their infinity prevents the anthropomorphic claim that reality is exhausted by the two forms accessible to us.

### 7.3 Leibniz and infinite analysis

Necessary truths terminate through finite analysis in identities; contingent truths require an infinite analysis completed only by God. This lets Leibniz say that a contingent predicate is contained in a subject's complete concept without becoming logically necessary. The cost is that contingency can look merely epistemic from the creature's standpoint.

## Rapid Recap Before Practice

1. Rationalism seeks necessity and certainty through reason, not the abolition of experience.
2. Descartes' order is doubt -> cogito -> God -> world.
3. Wax proves intellectual judgement of body, not the existence of body.
4. Substance count is 3 -> 1 -> ∞.
5. Spinoza's Thought and Extension are attributes, not substances.
6. Monads are simple, perceptive, appetitive and windowless.
7. God guarantees, is, and selects in Descartes, Spinoza and Leibniz respectively.
8. Mind-body solutions are interaction, parallelism and harmony.
9. Freedom is libertarian, rational self-determination and compatibilist spontaneity.
10. Every comparative answer must state the criterion of comparison.

## SOLVED PYQ WORKBOOK — VERIFIED 2018–2025

### Solved PYQ 1 — 2018 Q1(b), 10 marks

**Question:** Is there any place for freedom in Leibniz's philosophy, when he speaks of "pre-established harmony"? Discuss.

#### Model solution

Leibniz's pre-established harmony denies causal interaction among monads, but it does not reduce agency to external compulsion. Each monad unfolds its states from its own internal principle of perception and appetite; *Monadology* §7's "windowless" thesis therefore supports **spontaneity**, the first condition of freedom.

Freedom additionally requires **intelligence** and **contingency**. A rational monad acts for perceived reasons, not by blind physical impact. Although its predicates belong to its complete concept, Leibniz distinguishes certainty from absolute necessity: "Caesar crosses the Rubicon" is certain in this chosen world but its opposite is conceivable in another possible world. God's selection under the Principle of Sufficient Reason makes the series hypothetically, not logically, necessary.

The difficulty is that an act fixed in the complete concept seems unable to be otherwise in the actual world. Leibniz's answer is compatibilist: reasons "incline without necessitating," and an action is free when it flows intelligently from the agent rather than from coercion. Thus freedom survives, but not as Cartesian indifference.

**Verdict:** Pre-established harmony leaves a defensible place for responsible self-expression, though not for libertarian alternative possibilities.

**Why this earns marks:** It answers "any place" directly, links harmony to spontaneity, names complete concepts and possible worlds, and qualifies the claim.

### Solved PYQ 2 — 2018 Q2(a), 20 marks

**Question:** What is the reason for the difference in the definitions and classifications of substances made by Descartes, Spinoza and Leibniz in spite of the fact that they all belonged to the rationalist school of thought? Discuss.

#### Model solution

The difference arises not from abandoning rationalism but from successively tightening what counts as ontologically basic. All three inherit the idea that substance exists in itself and is conceived through itself; they disagree over independence, simplicity and individuation.

Descartes begins from clear-and-distinct **real distinction**. Thought and extension have mutually exclusive principal attributes, so mind and matter are created substances, while God is infinite substance. Yet *Principles* I.51 concedes that only God needs nothing whatever. "Substance" is therefore analogical: finite substances depend on God.

Spinoza applies the independence test strictly. In *Ethics* I, substances sharing an attribute cannot be distinct; a finite substance would have to be limited by another of the same nature. Hence only one infinite substance, God or Nature, exists. Minds and bodies become modes under Thought and Extension. This produces monism and pantheism but risks the acosmist charge that individuals lack independent reality.

Leibniz rejects both extended Cartesian substance and Spinozist absorption. Extension is divisible and composite, so it cannot be ultimate. True substances are simple centres of perception and appetite: infinitely many monads. The identity of indiscernibles differentiates them, while pre-established harmony explains correspondence without interaction. Bodies become well-founded phenomena.

Thus:

| Revision  | Criterion enforced               | Result                               |
|-----------|----------------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| Descartes | principal-attribute distinction  | dualist created substances under God |
| Spinoza   | absolute independence            | one infinite substance               |
| Leibniz   | simplicity and internal activity | infinitely many monads               |

Their shared rationalism supplies the deductive ambition, not a compulsory substance count. Indeed, the sequence is dialectical: Spinoza exposes Descartes' equivocation; Leibniz tries to restore individuality without returning to

extended substance.

**Verdict:** “Substance” is a criterion whose interpretation generates the metaphysics. The trio’s disagreement demonstrates rationalism’s internal development rather than its incoherence.

**Why this earns marks:** It explains the *reason* for divergence, uses named doctrines, compares mechanisms and costs, and avoids a merely descriptive table.

### Solved PYQ 3 — 2019 Q1(d), 10 marks

**Question:** How does Descartes prove the existence of things other than himself and God? Discuss.

#### Model solution

After the cogito and the proof of a non-deceiving God, Descartes argues in *Meditation VI* that material things probably cause his involuntary sensory ideas. He possesses a passive faculty of receiving such ideas; this requires an active cause. He has a strong natural inclination to attribute them to bodies. If no bodies existed and God directly caused this inclination, God would deceive him. Since a perfect God is no deceiver, material things exist.

The proof establishes **res extensa** more securely than the complete accuracy of perception. Descartes allows that senses misreport size, colour or distance; reason must correct them. The wax argument had already shown that the essence of body is extension, flexibility and changeability grasped by intellect, not a catalogue of sensible qualities.

The argument’s strength is systemic coherence: God bridges self and world. Its weakness is dependence on the contested divine proofs and Cartesian Circle. It also underdetermines whether external bodies resemble sensory appearances in detail.

**Verdict:** Descartes proves an external material cause within his system, but the result is only as secure as divine veracity.

**Why this earns marks:** It reconstructs the causal argument, distinguishes existence from perceived qualities, and evaluates the theological dependence.

### Solved PYQ 4 — 2019 Q2(c), 15 marks

**Question:** What do you understand by Spinoza’s statement that what is, cannot be other than what it is? Explain.

#### Model solution

The statement expresses Spinoza’s **necessitarianism**. God or Nature is the one self-caused substance, and *Ethics I* P16 holds that infinitely many things follow from the necessity of divine nature. Modes are not products of arbitrary choice; they follow from what substance is, as conclusions follow from adequate premises.

Three distinctions clarify the claim. First, God is free because God acts from the necessity of God’s own nature, not because God could choose contrary possibilities (*Ethics I* Def. 7). Second, contingency is a name for human ignorance of causes; *Ethics I* P29 denies contingency in nature. Third, finite things are determined by other finite modes within the single causal order.

This does not entail passive fatalism. Under Thought, an adequate idea understands a cause; under Extension, the same order is expressed bodily (*Ethics II* P7). A person becomes relatively free by replacing inadequate passions with adequate activity and seeing things *sub specie aeternitatis*.

Critics argue that necessity erases responsibility and novelty. Spinoza replies that blame based on an uncaused will is confused; ethical improvement consists in increasing rational power. The reply preserves self-determination but abandons the ability to do otherwise.

**Verdict:** “Cannot be other” means metaphysical causal necessity, not external fate. Spinoza saves freedom only by redefining it as intelligent participation in necessity.

**Why this earns marks:** It derives the quotation from substance, distinguishes necessity from fatalism, and links metaphysics to ethics.

### Solved PYQ 5 — 2020 Q1(b), 10 marks

**Question:** How does Leibniz’s conception of monads bear upon his views on determinism and freedom? Discuss with your own comments.

### Model solution

Monads are simple, windowless substances whose states arise internally through perception and appetite. Consequently, an agent is not mechanically pushed by other substances; conduct expresses the agent's complete concept. This supports determinism because the entire sequence is certain to God and coordinated through pre-established harmony.

Yet Leibniz treats internally sourced rational action as free. Freedom combines spontaneity, intelligence and contingency. The complete concept does not make acts logically necessary: other possible worlds contain alternative individuals and histories. Reasons incline the will without necessitating it in the way contradiction necessitates a truth.

In my view, the account successfully distinguishes coercion from self-expression and preserves responsibility better than Spinoza's strict necessitarianism. However, because the actual agent's complete concept is fixed, the availability of alternatives in other worlds may not satisfy a libertarian demand that this agent could now do otherwise.

**Verdict:** Monadology yields coherent compatibilism, not indeterministic freedom.

**Why this earns marks:** It connects monadic structure to both determination and freedom and includes the explicitly demanded personal assessment.

### Solved PYQ 6 — 2020 Q4(b), 15 marks

**Question:** "From the necessity of the divine nature there must follow infinitely many things in infinitely many ways." Explain this statement by Spinoza along with some possible criticisms.

### Model solution

In *Ethics* I P16, Spinoza derives the world from the essence of the one infinite substance. God has infinitely many attributes, each expressing eternal and infinite essence; therefore infinitely many modes follow in infinitely many ways. The relation is **immanent causation**: modes are in God, not external products made by a transcendent artisan.

The proposition supports four conclusions. God does not deliberate between worlds; divine action is necessary. Nothing is genuinely contingent; apparent contingency records ignorance. Thought and Extension express the same order under different attributes. Finite beings possess reality as modes, not independent substances.

Three criticisms follow. First, necessity threatens divine personality and worship: a God without choice resembles an impersonal order. Spinoza accepts the consequence and rejects anthropomorphism. Second, Hegel's acosmism objection says that if only substance is real, the finite disappears. Spinoza replies that modes are real as determinate expressions, though not self-subsistent. Third, strict derivation can seem to make evil and bondage divine necessities. Spinoza answers that good and evil are relational notions tied to human power, not properties of God.

**Verdict:** P16 gives Spinoza extraordinary systematic unity, but at the price of personality, contingency and robust individuality.

**Why this earns marks:** It explains the derivation, names P16 and immanent causation, and evaluates three distinct costs with replies.

### Solved PYQ 7 — 2022 Q2(c), 15 marks

**Question:** Discuss the concept of substance according to Spinoza. Does his discussion on substance lead to pantheism? Substantiate your view.

### Model solution

Spinoza defines substance as what is in itself and conceived through itself. In *Ethics* I, no two substances can share an attribute; substance cannot be finite because limitation would require another of the same nature. Therefore one absolutely infinite substance exists, possessing infinite attributes: God or Nature.

Thought and Extension are attributes known to human beings; particular minds and bodies are modes. *Ethics* I P15 states that whatever is, is in God, while P18 calls God the immanent rather than transitive cause. God does not stand outside and create Nature; *Natura naturans* and *Natura naturata* describe active nature and the order of modes.

This leads to pantheism in the precise sense that all reality is within and expressive of God, and nothing exists independently outside God. It is not crude identification of God with a mere aggregate of finite objects, because substance exceeds the two attributes humans know. The pantheist reading therefore qualifies but does not erase

the pantheistic implication.

Hegel's acosmism charge argues that the finite becomes unreal. Yet modes possess dependent reality as expressions of substance. My view is that Spinoza is best described as a philosophically qualified pantheist: divine immanence is undeniable, while divine infinity prevents reduction to the visible world alone.

**Why this earns marks:** It takes and substantiates a position, uses P15/P18 and the attribute-mode distinction, and answers the pantheism/acosmism debate.

### Solved PYQ 8 — 2022 Q4(b), 15 marks

**Question:** How does Rene Descartes explain the notion of certainty with reference to knowledge of the self? Critically discuss the way it differs from the knowledge of the world.

#### Model solution

Descartes discovers certainty by methodically suspending every belief vulnerable to sense error, dreaming or an evil demon. In *Meditation II*, "I am, I exist" is true whenever thought occurs: deception itself requires a deceived thinker. Knowledge of self is thus immediate, performative and independent of sensory mediation.

The self is first known as *res cogitans*: doubting, affirming, denying, imagining and seeming to sense. The wax case strengthens the priority claim: even if the wax does not exist, the act of judging reveals the judging mind. Hence mind is "better known" epistemically.

Knowledge of the world is mediate. Sensory ideas represent objects but can mislead; an external world is restored only after God's existence and non-deceptiveness are established. Even then, intellect identifies body's essence as extension, while reason corrects sensible appearances.

Critically, the cogito proves thinking existence, not automatically an enduring immaterial substance. Lichtenberg's later "there is thinking" objection and Hume's bundle critique expose this move. Moreover, the world-proof inherits the Cartesian Circle. Nevertheless, the asymmetry in certainty remains: self-presence survives the hypothesis under which world-presence is doubted.

**Verdict:** Descartes establishes epistemic priority of self over world, but not without further argument the full metaphysical dualism built upon it.

**Why this earns marks:** It compares modes of access, uses wax and divine veracity, and separates epistemic certainty from substantiality.

### Solved PYQ 9 — 2023 Q1(c), 10 marks

**Question:** "That thing is said to be free which exists solely from the necessity of its own nature, and is determined to action by itself alone." Discuss Spinoza's views on freedom and determinism.

#### Model solution

The quotation is *Ethics I* Definition 7. Spinoza rejects freedom as an uncaused choice. Every finite mode is determined within Nature's necessary order; humans imagine free will because they know desires but not their causes, as the conscious stone would mistake thrown motion for choice.

Only God is absolutely free because only God exists and acts from divine nature alone. Human freedom is relative: when inadequate ideas and external affects determine us, we are passive; when adequate ideas make us the adequate cause of action, we act from our understood nature. Reason and *scientia intuitiva* therefore transform necessity into self-determination.

The account is coherent but revisionary. It preserves rational agency and emotional liberation while denying alternative possibilities.

**Verdict:** Spinoza reconciles freedom with determinism by making freedom a higher form of determination, not an exception to causation.

**Why this earns marks:** It interprets the quoted definition, uses the stone analogy and adequate ideas, and ends with a qualified judgement.

### Solved PYQ 10 — 2023 Q2(c), 15 marks

**Question:** Discuss Descartes' theory of innate ideas and the grounds on which Locke refutes it.



### Model solution

Descartes distinguishes adventitious, factitious and innate ideas. Innate ideas are not necessarily explicit propositions present in an infant's consciousness; they are native capacities or intellectual contents, including God, substance, mind, extension and mathematical principles. In *Meditation* III, the idea of an infinite perfect being grounds the trademark argument because a finite mind cannot be its adequate total cause.

Locke attacks innate principles in *Essay* I. Universal assent is absent: children and persons without the relevant concepts do not consciously affirm alleged principles. Saying that principles are "in the mind" but unknown empties innateness of meaning, because by that standard every knowable truth would be innate. Locke instead begins with the mind as white paper and derives simple ideas from sensation and reflection.

Descartes can reply that innateness means a dispositional power, not constant awareness; geometrical knowledge is elicited rather than copied from sensation. Locke's argument decisively defeats crude occurrent innatism but less clearly defeats dispositional innatism. The empiricist must also explain necessity and universality without merely reporting repeated experience.

**Verdict:** Locke narrows the defensible Cartesian claim from preformed conscious truths to native cognitive structures; he refutes the caricature more securely than the strongest version.

**Why this earns marks:** It presents both theories fairly, identifies Locke's exact tests and gives a balanced adjudication.

### Solved PYQ 11 — 2024 Q2(b), 15 marks

**Question:** How does Spinoza establish that God alone is absolutely real with his statement — "Whatever is, is in God"? Critically discuss.

### Model solution

Spinoza's conclusion follows from his substance argument. Substance is in itself and conceived through itself; no two substances can share an attribute; an absolutely infinite substance must possess every attribute. Therefore God alone is substance, and *Ethics* I P15 concludes that everything else exists in God as a mode.

"In God" is ontological, not spatial. A mind is a mode under Thought and a body a mode under Extension; neither can be conceived independently. P18 adds that God is the immanent cause of things. God is therefore absolutely real because divine existence and conception depend on nothing else, while finite reality is derivative.

The view avoids a creator-world dualism and explains parallelism elegantly. Yet it faces three objections: the individuality of modes appears weakened; modal change seems hard to reconcile with eternal substance; and a personal providential God disappears. Spinoza can reply that independent reality is not the only reality, temporal order belongs to finite modes, and personality would anthropomorphise infinity.

**Verdict:** God alone is absolutely real, but finite things are not nothing; they are real relational expressions. This makes Spinoza monist and pantheistic without committing him to simple world-denial.

**Why this earns marks:** It derives P15, explains "in," distinguishes absolute and modal reality, and critically handles individuality.

### Solved PYQ 12 — 2024 Q3(c), 15 marks

**Question:** Among the rationalists, whose account of mind-body problem is compatible with the notion of human freedom and free will? Critically discuss.

### Model solution

Compatibility depends on the criterion of freedom. Descartes' interactionism separates unextended mind from mechanically determined body, permitting libertarian will. But Princess Elizabeth's objection remains: no intelligible account explains causal commerce between substances lacking a common property; the pineal gland merely gives a location.

Spinoza dissolves interaction by making mind and body the same mode under Thought and Extension (*Ethics* II P7). This is metaphysically economical but entails necessitarianism. Freedom becomes adequate self-determination, not free will as alternative choice.



Leibniz denies interaction because windowless monads unfold internally. Pre-established harmony coordinates mental and bodily series. Rational action remains spontaneous, intelligent and contingent because the actual world is one possible world chosen by God; truths about action are certain but not absolutely necessary.

If “free will” means ability to do otherwise, Descartes wins but with an unintelligible causal theory. If it means responsible agency compatible with systematic determination, Leibniz offers the strongest account. Spinoza offers the deepest self-mastery but openly rejects free will.

**Verdict:** Leibniz is the best qualified answer because his mind-body theory preserves internal agency and moral responsibility without Cartesian interaction, though it remains compatibilist rather than libertarian.

**Why this earns marks:** It explicitly ranks all three against stated criteria and defends the winner rather than neutrally describing positions.

### Solved PYQ 13 — 2025 Q2(a), 20 marks

**Question:** What are the basic tenets of Rationalism? How does Descartes build a system of Philosophy in consonance with them? Discuss.

#### Model solution

Rationalism holds that reason can yield necessary and universal knowledge through innate or self-evident principles, deduction and an intelligible structure of reality. Experience may occasion thought, but it cannot alone provide the certainty modelled by mathematics.

Descartes embodies these tenets as a system:

1. **Method over authority:** the four rules of the *Discourse* and hyperbolic doubt reject inherited opinion and seek evident beginnings.
2. **Self-evident foundation:** the cogito is grasped by intellectual intuition, not inferred from sensory evidence.
3. **Innate content:** ideas of God, substance, mind, extension and mathematical truths are native to rational cognition.
4. **Deductive reconstruction:** from the thinking self Descartes argues to a perfect God through the trademark, conservation and ontological routes.
5. **Intelligibility and truth:** a non-deceiving God guarantees clear-and-distinct perception, restoring mathematics and the external world.
6. **Substance metaphysics:** reality is ordered into infinite God and the created principal attributes of thought and extension.
7. **Mechanistic nature and rational freedom:** extended nature is mathematically governed, while the will can withhold assent; error occurs when will outruns intellect.

The system is rationalist not merely because it praises reason but because each stage seeks necessity independent of sensory contingency. The wax argument even makes intellect, rather than the senses, the judge of bodily identity.

Its vulnerabilities are equally systematic. The cogito may prove only occurring thought, not a Cartesian substance. The trademark and ontological arguments are disputed. Arnauld’s Circle suggests that the divine guarantee presupposes the criterion it secures. Locke attacks innate principles, while Kant later denies that existence is a real predicate.

**Verdict:** Descartes constructs the paradigm rationalist system—foundational, innate, deductive and substance-based—but its success beyond the cogito depends on theological premises less indubitable than its method demands.

**Why this earns marks:** It first defines the school, then maps every tenet onto a stage in Descartes, and finally evaluates the load-bearing weaknesses.

### Solved PYQ 14 — 2025 Q2(b), 15 marks

**Question:** “All determination is negation.” Comment with reference to Spinoza.

#### Model solution

The formula is associated with Spinoza’s Letter 50—“determination is negation”—and universalised in Hegelian reception. To determine a finite thing is to bound it as this rather than that; every limit excludes alternatives. Finitude

therefore contains negation.

In Spinoza's metaphysics, God or substance is absolutely infinite and determined by nothing external. God is pure positive self-expression through infinite attributes. Finite modes, by contrast, are limited by other modes: a body occupies this region and excludes others; a particular idea expresses only a bounded causal perspective. Their determination marks dependence and limitation.

The dictum also explains knowledge and freedom. Inadequate knowledge treats a finite thing in isolation; adequate knowledge understands it through the affirmative whole of Nature. The free person sees limitation and necessity *sub specie aeternitatis* rather than imagining an independent will.

Hegel's criticism is that Spinoza's infinite may swallow all finite determination, turning the world into negation—acosmism. Spinoza can answer that negation concerns independent self-subsistence, not every form of reality: modes positively express divine power in determinate ways.

**Verdict:** The dictum illuminates why finite beings are dependent, but it becomes reductive if limitation is mistaken for unreality. Spinoza needs both the negation of independence and the affirmation of modal expression.

**Why this earns marks:** It corrects provenance, explains the formula inside monism, links it to knowledge, and adjudicates the acosmism objection.

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## Integrated MCQ Loop — 24 Questions

| Q  | Question and options                                                                                                                                       | Key | Explanation                                                      |
|----|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----|------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1  | Descartes' doubt is primarily: A. methodical and temporary B. permanent scepticism C. theological faith D. sensory relativism                              | A   | It clears unstable beliefs to find an indubitable foundation.    |
| 2  | The wax argument chiefly shows: A. wax is unreal B. bodily identity is judged by intellect C. senses never function D. God is extension                    | B   | Changing sensible qualities do not exhaust the judged object.    |
| 3  | The Cartesian Circle concerns: A. mind-body interaction B. proof of the world C. mutual dependence of God and clear-distinct perception D. monadic harmony | C   | Each appears used to validate the other.                         |
| 4  | For Spinoza, Thought and Extension are: A. modes B. substances C. illusions D. attributes                                                                  | D   | They express one substance under two accessible aspects.         |
| 5  | Spinoza's first kind of knowledge is: A. imagination/opinion B. reason C. intuition D. recollection                                                        | A   | It arises from vague experience and signs and may be inadequate. |
| 6  | The fourth proportional grasped demonstratively exemplifies: A. imagination B. reason C. intuition D. revelation                                           | B   | Discursive mathematical proof belongs to the second kind.        |
| 7  | Leibniz rejects extension as ultimate because it is: A. unreal to sense B. divine C. divisible and composite D. self-caused                                | C   | Ultimate substance must be simple.                               |
| 8  | "Monads have no windows" means: A. they lack perception B. they are spatial C. they are identical D. they receive no causal influx                         | D   | Their changes arise internally.                                  |
| 9  | Descartes' God mainly functions epistemologically as: A. guarantor of clear-distinct truth B. one mode C. aggregate of bodies D. strongest monad           | A   | Divine non-deception bridges cogito and stable knowledge.        |
| 10 | Spinoza's God is best described as: A. transcendent artisan B. immanent substance C. finite intellect D. contingent selector                               | B   | God or Nature is the one substance.                              |
| 11 | Leibniz invokes the PSR to argue for: A. sensory atoms B. parallel attributes C. a sufficient ground of contingent reality D. denial of God                | C   | The contingent series requires a sufficient reason.              |
| 12 | Cartesian interaction is commonly located at the: A. heart B. optic nerve C. cerebellum D. pineal gland                                                    | D   | The location does not solve the conceptual causal gap.           |
| 13 | Spinozist parallelism says: A. mental and bodily orders express the same mode B. minds push bodies C. bodies are unreal D. God resets events               | A   | II P7 links the order of ideas and things.                       |
| 14 | Pre-established harmony is illustrated by: A. melting wax B. synchronized clocks C. a thrown stone D. a blank slate                                        | B   | Correspondence occurs without interaction.                       |
| 15 | Spinoza calls absolutely free what: A. is uncaused B. is random C. acts solely from its own nature D. defeats natural law                                  | C   | This is <i>Ethics</i> I Definition 7.                            |
| 16 | Leibnizian reasons: A. never affect choice B. logically necessitate every act C. are sensory impacts D. incline without necessitating                      | D   | This supports compatibilist freedom.                             |
| 17 | Descartes' error theory says error occurs when: A. will outruns intellect B. body disappears C. ideas interact D. God deceives                             | A   | The will assents beyond clear understanding.                     |

| Q  | Question and options                                                                                                                                                           | Key | Explanation                                                        |
|----|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----|--------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 18 | "Whatever is, is in God" is found in: A. <i>Monadology</i> §7 B. <i>Ethics</i> I P15 C. <i>Meditations</i> II D. Locke's <i>Essay</i> I                                        | B   | It states modal dependence on the one substance.                   |
| 19 | The acosmism objection says Spinoza: A. multiplies substances B. denies reason C. dissolves the finite world into substance D. accepts creation in time                        | C   | The finite appears to lose robust reality.                         |
| 20 | The complete-concept doctrine most threatens: A. extension B. innate ideas C. pantheism D. contingency and freedom                                                             | D   | Predicates fixed in the concept seem necessary.                    |
| 21 | Rationalism's deepest common commitment is: A. reason can disclose necessary intelligible structure B. all senses are false C. only one substance exists D. all wills are free | A   | Substance counts and freedom theories differ.                      |
| 22 | Descartes restores the external world after proving: A. monads B. a non-deceiving God C. parallelism D. common notions                                                         | B   | Divine veracity validates the natural inclination toward bodies.   |
| 23 | Spinoza's third kind of knowledge is: A. vague experience B. hearsay C. <i>scientia intuitiva</i> D. imagination                                                               | C   | It moves from divine attributes to essences in one adequate grasp. |
| 24 | The safest 2024 mind-body/freedom winner is: A. Spinoza always B. Descartes without qualification C. none can be compared D. Leibniz under a compatibilist criterion           | D   | The criterion must be explicitly defended.                         |

**Rotation audit:** Correct options follow A -> B -> C -> D six times.

## Remedial MCQ Loop — High-Risk Confusions

| Q  | Question and options                                                                                                                                                                                | Key | Why the correction matters                                     |
|----|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----|----------------------------------------------------------------|
| 25 | The cogito is best treated as: A. immediate performative certainty B. a syllogism from “all thinkers exist” C. sense inference D. proof of the body                                                 | A   | Descartes denies dependence on a suppressed major premise.     |
| 26 | Spinoza’s freedom is: A. randomness B. adequate self-determination C. exemption from causes D. bodily indifference                                                                                  | B   | It is a mode of necessity understood and internally expressed. |
| 27 | Leibnizian contingency means: A. God is ignorant B. events lack reasons C. the opposite is logically conceivable in another possible world D. complete concepts are false                           | C   | Certainty is distinguished from absolute necessity.            |
| 28 | Descartes calls mind and matter substances: A. in exactly God’s absolute sense B. because they create God C. because they are modes of Nature D. in a dependent/created sense                       | D   | This analogical use prompts Spinoza’s critique.                |
| 29 | Spinoza is most accurately called: A. a qualified pantheist/monist B. a simple atheist C. a Cartesian dualist D. an atomist                                                                         | A   | His God is impersonal but indispensable as substance.          |
| 30 | The wax argument does not by itself prove: A. intellectual judgement B. existence of external wax C. sensory change D. priority of self-awareness                                                   | B   | External existence is restored later through God.              |
| 31 | Parallelism avoids interaction by saying: A. God pushes both series B. matter causes mind C. one event is expressed under two attributes D. monads exchange signals                                 | C   | It dissolves the two-substance premise.                        |
| 32 | The phrase “all determination is negation” should be handled as: A. a direct sentence from <i>Meditations</i> B. Leibniz’s PSR C. Locke’s slogan D. Spinoza’s Letter 50 idea universalised by Hegel | D   | Accurate provenance is an evaluative mark-earner.              |

## Original Mains Practice

### Practice 1 — 10 marks

**Question:** Explain why the wax argument is necessary to Descartes’ rationalist project even after the cogito.

#### Model solution

The cogito establishes only that thinking existence is indubitable whenever thought occurs. The wax argument in *Meditation II* extends the result by showing how bodily identity is cognised. A fresh piece of wax loses taste, smell, shape, hardness and sound near fire, yet is judged to be the same wax. Neither a fixed sensory catalogue nor imagination covering indefinitely many possible shapes explains this judgement; *inspectio mentis* does.

The case therefore supports two rationalist claims. First, intellect contributes the concept of an extended, flexible and changeable thing. Second, every judgement of wax more certainly reveals the judging mind, even if the object is absent. The hats-and-coats example similarly converts apparent seeing into intellectual judgement.

However, the argument may presuppose extension as body’s essence, and an empiricist can treat it as abstraction. It proves intellectual structuring more clearly than innate knowledge.

**Verdict:** The wax turns the cogito from a bare certainty into an epistemological priority claim: mind is the condition under which body can be known.

**Why this earns marks:** It answers necessity, reconstructs the example, links it to rationalism and includes a precise limitation.

### Practice 2 — 15 marks

**Question:** Is Spinoza’s freedom merely determinism under a more attractive name? Critically examine.

### Model solution

Spinoza is a strict necessitarian: *Ethics* I P29 denies contingency, and finite modes are causally determined. If freedom requires the ability to do otherwise under identical conditions, his theory is indeed determinism renamed.

Yet *Ethics* I Definition 7 distinguishes external determination from action flowing from one's own nature. Human bondage consists in inadequate ideas and passive affects produced by partial causal understanding. Through common notions, reason and *scientia intuitiva*, the person becomes an adequate cause of action. The conscious-stone analogy attacks ignorance, not agency as such.

This is more than rhetorical relabelling because the distinction between passive and active determination has ethical consequences: understanding an affect changes one's relation to it and increases rational power. Still, every achievement of understanding is itself necessary, and alternative possibilities never return.

**Verdict:** Spinoza offers a substantive compatibilist ideal of self-mastery, but not free will in the libertarian sense. Its success depends on whether freedom is defined by authorship or alternatives.

**Why this earns marks:** It states both criteria of freedom, names textual evidence, shows practical significance and gives a graded ruling.

### Practice 3 — 20 marks

**Question:** "The history of rationalist substance is a movement from dualism through monism to pluralism." Analyse the logic and cost of this movement.

### Model solution

The sequence 3 → 1 → ∞ captures a real dialectic, but its logic lies in changing criteria rather than numerical preference. Descartes, Spinoza and Leibniz all seek self-explanatory reality accessible to reason.

Descartes uses principal attributes and real distinction. God is infinite substance; mind and body are created substances whose essences are thought and extension. The gain is a clear basis for mathematical nature and personal consciousness. The cost is definitional equivocation and the interaction problem.

Spinoza applies independence consistently. If substance is conceived through itself, dependent created substances cannot qualify; substances sharing attributes cannot be distinct. God or Nature alone remains, while minds and bodies are modes under Thought and Extension. The gain is unity and dissolution of interaction. The cost is necessitarianism and the threat of acosmism.

Leibniz accepts that extended composites are not ultimate but refuses to sacrifice individuals. Simplicity, perception and appetite define infinitely many monads. The gain is active plurality and internal agency. The cost is that bodies become phenomenal and correspondence requires pre-established harmony and a divine selector.

| Movement            | Problem solved                                        | New problem generated                            |
|---------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| Descartes → Spinoza | dependence and interaction between created substances | finite individuality and freedom weaken          |
| Spinoza → Leibniz   | restores genuine individual centres                   | harmony and complete concepts strain explanation |

The movement is therefore neither linear progress nor arbitrary disagreement. Each successor enforces one rationalist demand more strictly while paying elsewhere: coherence, individuality and experiential plausibility cannot all be maximised simultaneously.

**Verdict:** Rationalist substance evolves through internal criticism, revealing that the definition of the basic unit already contains a theory of causation, individuality and freedom.

**Why this earns marks:** It analyses the movement, names mechanisms and textual doctrines, balances gains with costs, and concludes at the conceptual level.